PERKALATE / RESTAURANTS

Viewed, Claimed, Redeemed: How to Tell if an Off Hours Promotion Worked

Covers alone won't tell you if a slow shift promotion worked. Track viewed, claimed and redeemed, plus second visits.

Most restaurants judge a promotion by looking at the room. If the bar felt busier on Tuesday, it worked. If it didn't, it didn't. That's understandable, and it's also how good ideas get killed early and bad ones run for months. A little structure goes a long way.

Why covers alone mislead

Total covers in a slow window move for plenty of reasons that have nothing to do with your offer: weather, a game on TV, a school holiday, a new opening down the block. If you only look at covers, you can't separate the promotion from the noise. You need numbers that only move because of the reward itself.

The three numbers that matter

Think of every reward as a simple funnel.

Viewed. How many people saw the reward. This tells you whether your placement and your audience are working at all.

Claimed. How many people decided they wanted it and took the step to claim. This tells you whether the offer is appealing to the people who see it.

Redeemed. How many people actually came in and used it. This is the number that pays the rent, and it tells you whether the path from interest to visit is smooth.

Each step tells you something different, which means each step points to a different fix.

Reading the funnel

Lots of views, few claims. The offer isn't compelling to this audience, or the rules are confusing. Try a different reward, simplify the wording, or rethink who you're showing it to.

Plenty of claims, few redemptions. Interest is there but something gets in the way. The hours may be wrong for the people claiming, the location may be harder to reach than you think, or staff may not be honoring it smoothly. Talk to your team before you change the offer.

Few views at all. This is a reach problem, not an offer problem. Your table tents may be in the wrong spot, or the audience you're targeting may be too narrow for your neighborhood.

Healthy at every step. Leave it alone for a while. The most common mistake is changing something that works because it feels stale to the people who see it every day.

The number behind the numbers: second visits

The redemption is the first visit. The real return comes when that guest comes back on their own. Wherever you can, track how many redeemers return within a few weeks. Even a rough count, such as staff noting familiar faces or a follow up reward that only returning guests can use, gives you a much better sense of value than redemptions alone.

What to expect in the first month

Be patient and be honest with yourself. The first couple of weeks are mostly about learning: which placement gets seen, which wording gets claimed, which hours people actually show up. Change one thing at a time so you know what made the difference. Write down what you changed and when.

If a partner brand funds the reward, share the same funnel with them. Brands are used to paying for impressions they can't verify. A clear count of how many people viewed, claimed and redeemed at your venue is something they rarely get, and it's the best argument for them funding the next one.

You don't need anyone's personal details

It's tempting to think good measurement requires collecting names and emails at the door. It doesn't. Aggregate counts tell you everything you need to make decisions, and they keep you out of the business of storing customer data you don't need. Guests are also far more willing to claim a reward when they aren't asked to hand over their information first.

Plan a pilot

Choose one audience, one reward and one result to measure. Set the budget and eligibility rules before launch. Tell participants which information you need and share results in aggregate where possible.